succumbed on March 27, in a campaign tent near Gibraltar. By now, the Christian kingdoms of Portugal, León-Castile, and Aragon had pushed all the way down to the Mediterranean. But the sole Muslim kingdom of Granada, ruled by Yusuf I, still clung to the southern coast; Alfonso was fighting against it when he died.

The throne of León-Castile (more often now simply referred to as "Castile") went to Alfonso's sixteen-year-old son Pedro. But rather than continuing to fight against Granada, Pedro of Castile began a war for territory with the king of neighboring Aragon, Pedro IV.

Meanwhile, Philip VI's oldest son was crowned King John II of France, inheriting a country that was "in a very unsatisfactory state," as Froissart writes. "The English were in possession of many places, especially of Calais, which caused the French considerable annoyance; moreover, their treasury was well-nigh exhausted." The famine and drought a few decades before had already weakened France; unending war and bubonic plague had carved still more strength away.[1]

The king of Navarre chose this moment to launch a bid for the French throne.

Charles of Navarre, Joan's son and heir, had long thought of himself as a Frenchman. From his father, the Count of Évreux, he had inherited substantial family lands in the north of France. He had married King John II's daughter, and had lived in France for much of his life. Even after his coronation, he used Navarre mostly as a source for income and soldiers.

In some ways, Charles's claim to the French crown was even stronger than Edward III's. Both hinged on the untimely death of Louis X, in 1316, at the age of twenty-seven, without a male heir. For both Edward and Charles, the passing of the crown to the Valois house was an injustice, one that disregarded the living Capetian heirs. But Edward was only Louis X's nephew; Charles was his grandson.

For the first five years of his reign, Charles of Navarre contented himself with raising supporters for his bid. The triple assembly of French nobility, clergy, and leading townsmen, first called by Philip the Fair in 1302, had been called several more times by Philip's successors, mostly to approve new taxes. Each time the three groups, or "estates," had acted as a single body: the "Estates-General," the first representative gathering of the French people. But the Estates-General had no power to pass laws, or to force the king to do anything; it merely offered counsel and advice. Across all three of the Estates, a healthy scattering of thoughtful men believed that the Estates should have a say in the king's decisions, particularly when it came to taxes or the reissuing of French currency (reissues inevitably sent prices either soaring or into